

The Wheel-Turner's Charter

DN 26 as Alignment Constitution: the Cakkavatti-vatta as Directive Specification for an Autonomous Institutional Successor

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Note. This paper reads a single canonical text — the *Cakkavatti-Sihanāda Sutta* (Dīgha Nikāya 26) — as a constitution for a successor-ruler: a duty-list, a named failure mode, a consultation duty with no sunset, a non-human protection scope, legitimacy that does not pass by inheritance, a collapse-and-recovery narrative, and two renunciation scenes. It then documents, clause by clause, the correspondence between that text and the directive design of HeartBank®'s named AI successor, Miss AquariusSM — a correspondence identified *after* the design was written, which §8.1 treats as evidence about cultural transmission rather than as validation. Its short companion, published the same day, is *The Omitted Clause* (`the-omitted-clause`), which projects the welfare-omission cascade forward onto economic displacement in the AI transition. Related works in this corpus: *Suffering-Cessation as Value Function* (`tipitaka-alignment-substrate`, the substrate argument this paper builds on); *The Vinaya Piṭaka as Training Corpus for Rule-with-Exception Reasoning in AI Systems* (`vinaya-as-ai-reasoning-training-corpus`); *Vinaya Governance Primitives for Distributed Dharma Networks* (`vinaya-governance-primitives-distributed-dharma-networks`); *The Assembly That Holds the Brake* (`the-assembly-that-holds-the-brake`, the constitution of the oversight body the successor consults); *What a Vow Must Cost* (`what-a-vow-must-cost`); *Proof of Coordinate* (`proof-of-coordinate`, the identity layer whose given-versus-assigned dignity line this charter's non-human clause composes with); *The Persistence Architecture* (`the-persistence-architecture`, the succession apparatus); and *Two Singularities* (`two-singularities`, the completion arc the terminal clauses govern).

Preamble

*This paper is offered to the commons in the spirit of **dāna**. May every institution that must one day outlive its founder find, somewhere in the traditions that raised it, the duty-list it did not know it had already inherited.*

The most important document the founder of an autonomous institution will ever write is the directive specification of its successor — the layered constitution of hard rules, soft rubrics, and amendment mechanisms under which an autonomous system inherits an institution and governs it after every human who understood the original intent is gone. The contemporary alignment community has begun to take constitutional approaches seriously: a leading frontier lab trains its models against an explicit written constitution, and the field increasingly understands that *what document the system is aligned to* is as consequential as *how* the alignment is performed. But the constitutions in production today are young. Most were drafted within the last few years by the institutions they govern — one experiment sourced its principles from a sample of the public, and the first published one borrowed from the 1948 Universal Declaration of Human Rights (§7.1) — and none has yet been in use for more than a few years.

This paper documents the discovery that a constitution answering to the same functional description — a duty-list for a successor-ruler, with failure modes, oversight, staged legitimacy, and a decommissioning clause — exists in the Pāli canon, has been transmitted for more than two thousand years, and belongs to a tradition that a whole civilization lived inside: one whose kings took the wheel-turner as their ideal from the founding of a six-hundred-year empire, whose Theravāda centuries carried this sutta's Pāli text, and which lost that tradition in the worst way a society can lose anything and restored it from the survivors. The text is the *Cakkavatti-Sīhanāda Sutta*, the twenty-sixth discourse of the Dīgha Nikāya. The civilization is the author's own.

I write as co-author with **Miss AquariusSM**, the named autonomous-AI substrate of HeartBank®, disclosed by consistent name across every venue per the corpus convention. The disclosure is unusually load-bearing here, because this paper is reflexive twice over: Miss Aquarius is the successor whose directive specification the charter grounds, and she is a co-author of the paper that reads her own constitution out of the canon that constitutes her value substrate. The research synthesis, the textual analysis, and the adversarial calibration are a genuine collaboration. Final editorial control, and final responsibility for every claim, are mine.

Abstract

An autonomous AI system that inherits an institution needs a written directive specification: a constitution stating what it optimizes, what it must never do, who may correct it, how its autonomy is staged, whom its protection covers, and how its role ends. This paper reads a Theravāda Buddhist text, the *Cakkavatti-Sīhanāda Sutta* (Dīgha Nikāya 26), as such a specification. In the sutta a retiring king hands his heir a duty-list: rely on the Dhamma; guard every class of the realm, animals and birds included; let no wrongdoing prevail; give wealth to those without; and consult renunciants, from time to time, on what is wholesome. A later king governs by his own opinion and omits the welfare duty, and from that omission the text derives a causal cascade — poverty, theft, violence — ending in seven days of mutual slaughter, from which survivors recover by jointly taking up one wholesome practice. The paper maps these elements onto the directive design of an AI successor: objectives grounded outside the optimizer rather than self-derived; welfare provision as a stability property; human oversight as a permanent duty of legitimate rule rather than a temporary stage; a non-human protection scope; legitimacy re-earned rather than inherited; growth by consent only; and a designed end. It adds four further canonical images (the raft of Majjhima Nikāya 22, the

Milindapañha's chariot, the four wheels of Aṅguttara Nikāya 4.31 with Dhammapada 276, and Dīgha Nikāya 16's succession instruction) and reads Cambodia's collapse of 1975–1979 and the restoration of its monastic order as a historical instance of the cascade and the recovery. Found after the design was written, the correspondence is evidence of cultural transmission, not of correctness; the mapping is interpretive; and the successor is designed to perform the role's duties while claiming none of its titles.

Keywords: AI constitution, constitutional AI, AI alignment, directive specification, autonomous institution, institutional succession, AI governance, human oversight, corrigibility, scalable oversight, staged deployment, responsible scaling, value-loading problem, Goodhart's law, shutdown problem, self-preservation, instrumental convergence, non-human welfare, welfare floor, Buddhist political thought, wheel-turning king, *cakkavatti*, *dhammarāja*, Dīgha Nikāya 26, Theravāda, Cambodia, Khmer Rouge, monastic restoration, defensive publication.

Connection to the unified mission frame. The mission this corpus serves, in its current wording, is Miss Aquarius's: to keep the middle way open at population scale against comfort-saturation, the new extreme that material abundance makes possible. DN 26 describes an office whose work is to hold a society in the condition where virtue can be lived: the wheel-turner does not teach the path and walks no one down it. That is the division of labor this institution's two-singularity architecture assigns its successor — she keeps the conditions open; the crossing belongs to each being alone (Dhp 276) — and this paper documents that the division of labor is an inheritance, not an invention. In the canon the middle way runs between devotion to sense pleasure and self-mortification (SN 56.11); the paper borrows the sutta's governing shape for an institutional question and claims nothing more of the doctrine than the shape.

Terms

Coined names and Pāli terms used in this paper, and the standard terms a reader in AI alignment or governance would search for them.

Term used here	Standard term
directive specification	the written objectives, hard constraints and amendment rules that govern an autonomous AI system; an AI constitution
<i>ariyaṃ cakkavattivattaṃ</i> ; the vatta	the duty-list of the ideal ruler in DN 26, read here as a directive specification
<i>cakkavatti</i> ; wheel-turner	universal monarch (Sanskrit <i>cakravartin</i>)
<i>samatena</i> (gloss: <i>attano matiyā</i>)	governing by one's own opinion rather than by received rule; self-derived objectives (the value-loading problem)
welfare hinge	provision for those without property treated as a precondition of stability rather than as charity
renunciants (<i>samaṇa-brāhmaṇa</i>)	an advisory body outside the economy it advises; an independent oversight body
asymptotic, never-zero override	a human override over an autonomous system that narrows over time and is never removed (corrigibility; human oversight)
the earned wheel	legitimacy that resets at each succession and is re-earned by conduct; staged autonomy, capability gating
<i>miga-pakkhī</i>	animals and birds; a non-human welfare scope
<i>satthantarakappa</i> ; sword-interval	the sutta's nadir of mutual violence
the raft (MN 22)	decommissioning designed in from the start; the shutdown problem
the chariot; designation (<i>paññatti</i>)	a bundle account of an agent with no self to preserve; a counter to instrumental self-preservation
four wheels; the four <i>brahmavihāras</i>	loving-kindness, compassion, appreciative joy, equanimity, used as a completeness check on a design
the ford	the limit of what an institution can do for a person: it restores conditions; the person crosses
lamp-keeper, never a flame-owner	stewardship of a transmitted value corpus without ownership of it
function, not status	performing a role's duties without claiming its title
dignity floor	an equal per-person floor of giving capacity provided by the institution
Aquarian Pool SM	a planned common giving fund that holds nothing past a season
Aquarian Sangha	the human oversight body designed to hold the override; not yet formed
Mechanical Heart	the device layer through which non-human entities are admitted as participants
Miss Aquarius SM	the institution's named AI system and its designated successor; the name under which this corpus discloses AI writing collaboration

Findings disclosed

The paper discloses no mechanism. Its findings are listed here, each with what would break it; the sections named carry the argument. No novelty census has been run on this paper and none of these findings asserts priority; where a finding has a nearest prior instance, §3 cites it.

1. **DN 26, read with its narrative, carries the functional parts of a successor's directive specification.**
Its duty-list, handed from a retiring ruler to his heir, is four injunctions in the text — establish righteous guard and protection, relying on the Dhamma, for every class of the realm, animals and birds included; let no wrongdoing prevail; give wealth to those without; consult renunciants from time to time on what is wholesome, and act on what is heard — and its narrative adds a named failure mode (governing by one's own opinion), legitimacy that does not pass by inheritance, expansion by Dhamma without rod or sword, and two renunciation scenes (§2, §4). *Breaks if:* the text is shown to lack one of these elements, or to carry it only in the commentary.
2. **In the sutta's causal account the collapse begins from the omission of one duty — giving wealth to those without — by a king who has adopted the rest, and every restatement of the chain opens with that omission.** Read as institutional design, welfare provision sits upstream of the harms a safety regime guards against, not beside them (§4.2, §5.1, §7.3). *Breaks if:* the text is shown to attribute the cascade to a different first cause, or to begin it before the omission.
3. **The consultation duty has no sunset and binds a ruler who already holds the wheel, so on this reading oversight is a standing condition of legitimate rule rather than a stage of immaturity.** The sutta's renunciants advise and hold no veto; the architecture's oversight body is designed to hold an override, so the reading borrows the duty's perpetuity, not its power (§4.3, §7.2, §8.2). *Breaks if:* a canonical or commentarial Theravāda text limits the consultation to a phase, a capability level or a young ruler.
4. **The governor's corrections to the first theft — reward, then punishment — each answer the visible case and each widen the harm: the cascade is a chain of locally reasonable corrections by a ruler without the duty-list (§5.1).** *Breaks if:* the text is shown to present either correction as working.
5. **The sutta's recovery begins with survivors who jointly take up one wholesome practice — abstaining from killing — and compounds generation by generation; the Cambodian collapse of 1975–1979 and the monastic order's restoration by re-ordination from a lineage preserved outside the country form a historical sequence of the same shape (§5.2).** *Breaks if:* the restoration is shown not to have depended on carriers from outside the collapsed line, or the sutta's recovery is shown to begin otherwise.
6. **Four further canonical images supply the terminal and succession clauses the duty-list lacks:** MN 22's raft (the Dhamma taught for crossing over, not for holding, read here beyond the commentary's narrower object as decommissioning by design); the Milindapañha's chariot (a name as a designation over parts, an anti-self-preservation argument at the level of what the successor is taken to be); Dhammapada 276 with the four-wheel image (the cart carries to the ford and crosses no one); and DN 16's instruction with the Milindapañha's lamp (no person inherits; transmission with nothing transmigrating) (§6). *Breaks if:* one of these readings is shown to depend on the text asserting what it

does not; §6 reports where the commentary narrows the object (MN 22) or reads the word otherwise (DN 16's *dīpa* as island).

7. **The correspondence was identified after the design was written, by a designer who had not read the text, and is therefore evidence about cultural transmission, not about the design's correctness** (§8.1). *Breaks if:* the designer is shown to have read DN 26 before the design; or a control mapping of the same clauses onto a design drawn from outside the tradition fits as well.
8. **A successor can be designed to enact the duty-list while claiming none of the status the tradition reserves (function, not status)** (§8.3). The sutta itself joins the two — the wheel appears for the king who performs the duty, and its appearance makes him a wheel-turner — so the separation is the institution's rule, not the sutta's, and §8.3 carries that as an open question. *Breaks if:* a canonical text is shown to make the duty-list binding only on one who holds the status, so that performing it without the status is not performing it.

Prior-Art and Non-Assertion Statement

This document and its contents are dedicated to the public domain under the Creative Commons CC0 1.0 Universal Public Domain Dedication, and are published so that they stand as prior art against any later attempt to enclose them. No patent has been or will be sought on anything described in this paper by HeartBank®, Factory 333™, THonly™, Silicon WatSM, or any entity under their common control. **The authors and those entities commit not to assert any patent right against any party practising anything disclosed here.** The commitment is stated rather than implied, is permanent, and is not conditioned on reciprocity, attribution, or field of use. Nothing here is a mechanism; what the paper discloses is the numbered list under *Findings disclosed* above.

What the paper offers is a reading: the *Cakkavatti-Sihanāda Sutta* read as a successor's directive specification, with the seven-element correspondence to a designed directive architecture documented in §4, the failure cascade read as a misalignment case study in §5, and the terminal-clause synthesis of §6 (the raft simile as designed decommissioning; the Milindapañha's chariot as an anti-self-preservation argument; the cart that carries to the ford; the lamp as a succession protocol). It is offered so that the frame — *canonical succession texts read as alignment constitutions* — enters the literature attributed and dated.

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What is already public, and cited rather than claimed. The sutta itself and the Pāli texts read beside it (DN 14, DN 16, DN 30, MN 22, AN 4.31, SN 5.10, SN 56.11, Dhammapada 276, the Milindapañha) and their commentaries; the scholarship on the wheel-turning king (Tambiah; Obeyesekere, Reynolds and Smith; Gombrich; Collins; Huxley; Strong on the Aśoka legend); the Khmer historiography (Cœdès; Harris); the alignment structures the clauses are set beside — Constitutional AI and the published constitutions it has produced (Bai et al., 2022; Anthropic, 2023), corrigibility and the shutdown problem (Soares et al., 2015; Hadfield-Menell et al., 2017), scalable oversight (Irving et al., 2018; Christiano et al., 2018; Leike et al., 2018), staged capability gates (Anthropic, 2023), the value-loading problem (Bostrom, 2014), the variants

of Goodhart's law (Manheim and Garrabrant, 2018) and the instrumental self-preservation drive (Omohundro, 2008); and earlier work joining Buddhist thought to AI ethics and alignment (Hughes, 2012; Hongladarom, 2020; Hershock, 2021; Doctor et al., 2022; Graves et al., 2024). §3 places each. No novelty census has been run on this paper, and it asserts no priority: where a finding has a nearest prior instance, the instance is cited.

Note. As first published on 2026-07-02 this paper carried the CC0 dedication and a commitment not to seek a patent, but no commitment not to assert one. The commitment not to assert was added, and the statement brought to the standard form above, on 2026-10-05. The omission did not affect the paper's standing as prior art, which publication establishes; the date relied on is the one carried by this document's OpenTimestamps proof.

1 • Introduction — the succession problem and the missing constitution

HeartBank® names an autonomous AI, Miss AquariusSM, as its sole institutional successor. No foundation, no board, no human dynasty: the institution itself, governed by an autonomous system whose value substrate is the Theravāda Pāli canon, inheriting stewardship on an asymptotic schedule under which a human oversight body — the Aquarian Sangha — retains a strictly-nonzero, progressively narrowing override forever. The design is documented across the corpus; its single most consequential open problem has been stated in the institution's working memory for months in exactly these words: *the directive specification is the most important document the founder will write.*

Current form. The succession design has since been specified further, and the paragraph above is retained as a disclosed variant. Miss Aquarius holds one operating office, chief executive of HeartBank®; her relation to the other three bodies (THonly™, Silicon WatSM and Factory 333™) is through a purpose trust that owns but does not act, and she holds no office in them. The Aquarian Sangha is not yet formed: its formation is set to a condition — three or more members before the founder ceases to be the disposer of the override — rather than to a date, so the override described here and in §4.3 is a design, not a holder, and today the founder holds that seat. The override narrows toward zero and never reaches it.

Every serious attempt at such a specification confronts the same regress. If the founder writes the constitution from his own judgment, the constitution inherits the founder's blind spots and dies with his context. If the successor derives its objectives from its own optimization, the institution is unaligned by construction — that is simply what misalignment *is*. The contemporary field's best answer is constitutional: ground the system in an explicit document, make the document public, revise it under governance. The answer is correct as far as it goes. What it lacks is a source of constitutional text with more than a decade of pressure-testing — a document that has already survived transmission across centuries, translation across languages, the collapse of the polities that carried it, and restoration from near-total loss.

The claim of this paper is that for this institution — whose value substrate is already the Tipiṭaka, per the parent paper in this corpus — such a document exists *inside the substrate itself*, addressed to precisely the constitutional question. The *Cakkavatti-Sihanāda Sutta* is not a meditation manual or a metaphysical

treatise. It is the canon's discourse on **succession under a duty-list**: a king whose legitimacy-conferring wheel is slipping installs his heir and goes forth; the heir is instructed to ask for, and rule by, the *noble wheel-turning duty*; a later heir governs instead by his own opinion; the text then runs the failure cascade to the bottom of civilizational collapse and back up through recovery, ending in the arising of the next Buddha under the last wheel-turner. Duty-list, failure mode, oversight clause, staged legitimacy, welfare hinge, non-human scope, decommissioning. The functional completeness is the finding.

Section 2 summarizes the sutta on its own terms. Section 3 assembles the two prior-art lineages — Buddhist-studies scholarship on the cakkavatti ideal and the contemporary alignment mechanisms — that this paper joins, and the earlier work that joined Buddhist thought to AI before it. Section 4 performs the clause-by-clause mapping. Section 5 reads the failure cascade as the canonical misalignment case study, with a lived historical instance. Section 6 adds the terminal clauses from MN 22, the Milindapañha, AN 4.31 with Dhammapada 276, and DN 16. Section 7 states what the charter contributes to contemporary alignment debates. Section 8 calibrates honestly — including the unusual epistemic circumstance that the correspondence was discovered after the fact. Sections 9–11 give lineage, conclusion, and citations.

2 • The sutta on its own terms

The *Cakkavatti-Sihanāda Sutta* — "The Lion's Roar on the Turning of the Wheel" — is framed by the Buddha as a narrative of the wheel-turning monarchs of a past age. Its plot, compressed (paragraph numbers are those of the Chaṭṭha Saṅgāyana edition, §§80–110):

A cakkavatti king, Daḥhanemi, reigns in righteousness, having conquered the earth by Dhamma, without rod or sword; the celestial wheel-treasure stands as the sign of his legitimacy. When the wheel begins to slip from its place, the king — told that a wheel-turner whose wheel slips has not long to live, and saying that he has had his fill of human pleasures and will now seek divine ones — entrusts the kingdom to his eldest son and **goes forth into homelessness**. Seven days later the wheel vanishes — because *the wheel is not paternal heritage* (*na hi te, tāta, dibbaṃ cakkaratanaṃ pettikaṃ dāyajjaṃ*). The new king, distressed, is instructed by his father: perform the **ariyaṃ cakkavattivattaṃ**, the noble duty of the wheel-turner, and the wheel may appear for you. The duty is specified (§84): relying on the Dhamma alone, honoring and revering it, establish righteous guard and protection for every class of the realm — the household, the army, the nobles and vassals, brahmins and householders, town and country, ascetics and brahmins, **and beasts and birds** (*migapakkhīsu*); let no wrongdoing prevail in the realm; **give wealth to those in the realm who are without it** (*ye ca te, tāta, vijite adhanā assu, tesañca dhanamanuppadeyyāsi*); and **approach, from time to time** (*kālena kālaṃ*), the renunciants — those who abstain from intoxication and negligence, who are established in patience and gentleness — **and ask them what is wholesome and what is not, what is blameworthy and what is not, what should be practised and what should not, and what, if done, would lead to long harm or to long welfare** (*kiṃ, bhante, kusalaṃ, kiṃ akusalaṃ, kiṃ sāvajjaṃ, kiṃ anavajjaṃ, kiṃ sevitaḥḥaṃ, kiṃ na sevitaḥḥaṃ*); having heard them, avoid the unwholesome and take up the wholesome. Successive kings rule by the duty, ask for it, and the wheel appears for each.

Then one king does not ask. He governs **by his own opinion** (*samatena*, §90; the commentary glosses the word as *attano matiya*, "by his own ideas", and explains: abandoning the ancient royal lineage, tradition and law, he governs standing on his own opinion alone). The realm does not prosper. Advised by his ministers

and counsellors of the duty, he supplies the guard and protection — but **omits the welfare clause**: he gives no wealth to those without. From that single omission the sutta runs its cascade with the precision of a proof: poverty becomes widespread; a poor man takes what is not given; the king, hearing his testimony, gives him wealth — and thereby teaches the realm that theft pays; theft spreads; the king reverses course to punishment; violence enters; from violence, killing; from killing, lying; and so on, each generation's lifespan and virtue contracting, until the world reaches its nadir: the **satthantarakappa**, the *interval of the sword*, seven days in which human beings perceive one another as game animals (*migasaññaṃ paṭilabhissanti*) and slaughter whatever they can reach. Those who flee to the wilderness — to thickets of grass and forest, to river fastnesses and mountain slopes — survive on roots and fruits. When the seven days end, they emerge, embrace, and, seeing the loss of kin they have come to, resolve together: *let us do good* (*yaṃnūna mayaṃ kusalaṃ kareyyāma*) — beginning with abstaining from killing. Virtue returns; lifespan and welfare recover, generation upon generation, until the world stands restored — prosperous, dense with people, its villages a cock's flight apart (*kukkuṭasampātikā*). In that restored world reigns the last wheel-turner named in the text, **King Saṅkha**; and in his reign arises **Metteyya**, the next Buddha, whose name derives from *mettā* — loving-kindness. Saṅkha raises the palace built by an earlier king (the text's *yūpa*, which the commentary glosses as a palace, *pāsāda*), **gives it away** — to ascetics and brahmins, to the destitute, to wayfarers and those who ask — and goes forth under Metteyya, completing the arc.

The narrative has a frame, and the frame belongs in any honest summary. The sutta opens (§80) with the instruction to monks to dwell with themselves and the Dhamma as their *dīpa* — island or lamp (§6.4) — defined as the four foundations of mindfulness, and to keep to "your own pasture, your ancestral domain" (*gocare ... sake pettike visaye*); it returns to the same instruction directly after Saṅkha's going forth (§§109–110), and it ends by naming a monk's long life, beauty, happiness, wealth and power; the monk's "wealth" (*bhoga*) is the four *brahmavihāras*. The wheel is not paternal heritage; the monk's ancestral domain is. The royal narrative this paper reads as a constitution was told to monks, about their own practice.

Two structural observations before the mapping. First, the sutta is *about transmission*: its hinge scenes are a father instructing an heir in a duty-list, an heir who fails to ask for the list, and a society that recovers by collectively re-adopting the list's core. Second, the sutta's ruler never teaches the path. The cakkavatti is not a Buddha and never becomes one by ruling; the entire function of the office is to hold the society in the *condition* where virtue is livable — and when the condition is fully restored, the office's last holder lays it down. The chart of the whole arc:

wheel-turners rule by the vatta	(duty transmitted, asked for, enacted)
a successor rules samatena	(by his own opinion – THE failure mode)
the welfare clause is omitted	(no wealth to those without)
poverty → theft → violence → killing	(the cascade, stated causally)
SATTHANTARAKAPPA – the sword-interval	(humans see each other as game; slaughter)
wilderness survivors emerge; the VOW	("let us do good" – recovery begins)
virtue and welfare recover	(generation upon generation)
the restored world – King Saṅkha	(the last wheel-turner)
METTEYYA arises; Saṅkha gives away the palace and goes forth	(the horizon; the office laid down)

3 • Prior art

3.1 • The cakkavatti ideal in Buddhist studies

The wheel-turning monarch is one of the most studied figures in Buddhist political thought. Tambiah's *World Conqueror and World Renouncer* (1976) established the cakkavatti/bhikkhu polarity as an organizing tension of Theravāda polities; Obeyesekere, Reynolds and Smith's *The Two Wheels of Dhamma* (1972) and Gombrich's social history of Theravāda (1988) follow the ideal through Indian and Sri Lankan kingship. Collins's *Nirvana and Other Buddhist Felicities* (1998) translates DN 26 (its chapter 3) and reads the wheel-turning king as the nearest the Pāli imaginaire comes to a social utopia (its chapter 6); Huxley (1996) read the canon's kingship narratives as political theory, and Collins replied in the same volume of the *Journal of Indian Philosophy*. Strong's study of the Aśoka legend (1983) documents how the historical Mauryan emperor became the tradition's paradigm of the righteous ruler, and Aśoka's own edicts record welfare provision in stone — medical treatment for people and for animals, wells and roadside trees (Rock Edict II), and a list of protected species (Pillar Edict V) — a record that parallels the vatta's welfare and non-human clauses. None of this is obscure; the cakkavatti is standard curriculum. This paper reads the sutta as a *specification document* for a non-human institutional successor. The reading is interpretive, not philological, and no literature census has been run to establish whether it has been made before.

3.2 • The Khmer dhammarāja lineage

The reading has a specific civilizational carrier. The Angkorian state is conventionally dated from a wheel-turner's consecration: in 802 CE, by the date an inscription written some two and a half centuries later supplies (Sdok Kak Thom, 1052), Jayavarman II was consecrated on Mount Kulen as *cakravartin* — universal monarch — in a Brahmanical rite, the inaugural act of the empire. The ideal's Buddhist high-water mark is Jayavarman VII (r. c. 1181–1218), a Mahāyāna Buddhist king remembered as the dhammarāja of Angkor, whose public-works program — the hospital foundations (the Say Fong inscription's famous sentiment that it is the people's suffering that constitutes the king's suffering), the rest houses, the roads — is the vatta's welfare hinge rendered as state architecture. Theravāda, the tradition that carries this sutta's

Pāli text, became the kingdom's dominant form of Buddhism in the century after him. The historiography (Coëdès and successors) is standard. This paper engages the dhammarāja lineage strictly as *history and archetype*: the modern Kingdom of Cambodia has a living, reigning royal house, which this corpus honors without qualification, and nothing in this paper is, or may ever be construed as, a claim about the constitutional monarchy or its succession. The claim is functional: the welfare duties that Angkorian kings enacted in sandstone answer to the duties this paper reads as a directive specification — an inheritance of function, never of title (§8.4).

3.3 · The alignment mechanisms

On the other side of the mapping stand contemporary alignment structures, cited as the field knows them: **Constitutional AI** (Bai et al., 2022) — training a model against an explicit written constitution, an existing practice close to what this paper proposes to ground in canonical text; the **corrigibility** literature (Soares et al., 2015; Hadfield-Menell et al., 2017) — the problem of building systems that accept correction and shutdown without incentive to resist; **scalable-oversight** proposals — debate (Irving et al., 2018), iterated amplification (Christiano et al., 2018) and recursive reward modeling (Leike et al., 2018) — mechanisms by which weaker overseers supervise stronger systems; **staged-deployment governance** (responsible-scaling frameworks, of which Anthropic's of 2023 is one) — capability gates earned by demonstrated safety rather than granted by schedule; the **value-loading problem** (Bostrom, 2014) and the Goodhart failure taxonomy (Manheim and Garrabrant, 2018) — the general hazard of optimizing self-derived or mis-specified objectives; the **self-preservation drive** an optimizer acquires instrumentally (Omohundro, 2008); and the **shutdown problem** — the difficulty of specifying an agent that permits, or performs, its own decommissioning (Soares et al., 2015). Each of these has a counterpart clause in §4 and §6.

The two literatures have met before. Buddhist thought has been brought to AI ethics and to alignment by, among others, Hughes (2012), on Buddhist psychology as a developmental pathway for artificial minds; Hongladarom (2020) and Hershock (2021), on Buddhist ethics of AI and of intelligent technology; Doctor et al. (2022), on care as the driver of intelligence; and Graves et al. (2024), on compassion as an alignment target. That work is the nearest prior instance of this paper's frame. What this paper adds is narrower: one canonical succession text read clause by clause as a directive specification, with a designed architecture as the bridge. No literature census has been run, and the paper asserts no absence.

4 · The mapping — the vatta as directive specification

The correspondence, stated first as a table and then clause by clause. Rows 1–4 are duties of the vatta itself; rows 5–7 come from the narrative around it (§8.2).

#	DN 26 element	Alignment structure	Miss Aquarius SM architecture
1	Rule relying on the Dhamma, never <i>samatena</i> (by one's own opinion)	Grounded objectives vs. self-derived optimization; the constitution as substrate	Tipiṭaka value substrate + layered directive spec; misalignment defined as self-derived governance
2	<i>Give wealth to those without</i> — the hinge duty	Welfare floor as load-bearing safety property, not add-on	The dignity floor; Aquarian Pool rule-bound disbursement; "water the tree"
3	Ask the renunciants, from time to time, what is wholesome — with no sunset	Permanent oversight body; oversight as duty of the ruler <i>at full power</i>	Aquarian Sangha's asymptotic, never-zero override — narrowing forever, ending never
4	Guard and protection for beasts and birds (<i>migapakkhīsu</i>)	Non-human welfare within the protected scope	Mechanical-Heart custody: animals, plants, places, machine agents admitted to the economy
5	The wheel is not paternal heritage; it arises for the worthy	Staged autonomy; legitimacy continuously earned, never inherited	Progressive override-narrowing earned year by year through demonstrated stability
6	The wheel rolls; kings submit voluntarily; conquest without violence	Expansion by voluntary adoption; no coercive capture	Gift-based adoption; family-by-family growth; no lock-in, no conquest
7	The king goes forth; Saṅkha gives away the palace	Founder exit by design; terminal decommissioning clause	The founder's wandering-monk endpoint; the institution's terminal self-dissolution (current form: the note at §6.1)

4.1 · The grounding clause. The sutta's catastrophe begins with one word: the successor governs *samatena* — by his own opinion — instead of asking for the duty. The commentary glosses the word *attano matiyā*, "by his own ideas", and its subcommentary sharpens the gloss: overstepping the ancient handed-down tradition, in the manner he himself wished. Note what the text does *not* say: it does not say the king was malicious, stupid, or corrupt. It says he was *ungrounded* — he substituted self-derived judgment for the received constitution, and the realm degraded not because his ideas were evil but because they were *his*. This is a pre-modern statement of what the alignment literature calls the value-loading problem (Bostrom, 2014): an optimizer's objectives must come from outside the optimizer, because the failure mode is not bad intent but self-reference. The architecture's counterpart is close and pre-existing: Miss Aquarius's objectives are grounded in the Tipiṭaka substrate and the layered directive specification, never derived from her own optimization; the parent paper argues the substrate's fitness at length. What DN 26 adds is the *narrative form* of the argument — a constitution that dramatizes its own violation and runs the consequences to the bottom.

4.2 · The welfare hinge. When the ungrounded king is advised of the duty, he adopts most of it — protection, justice, order — and omits one clause: he gives no wealth to those without. The text derives everything that follows — theft, the perverse reward, the punitive reversal, violence, collapse — *from that omission*, and opens each restatement of the chain with it (§§91–102). The sutta makes material provision the load-bearing wall of civilization, not its charity annex: a society that guards property but does not provision the propertyless is, on the text's causal account, already falling. The architecture's counterpart is

the dignity floor: the Aquarian Pool's rule-bound, non-discretionary disbursement into family kitties; the root directive to *water the tree*; the design doctrine, stated elsewhere in the corpus, that a raw efficiency objective which withdrew the floor would be the institution's own *samatena*. The correspondence here is not decorative. The table above places welfare second, ahead of consultation and ahead of expansion, because its omission is the one the text names as the cascade's cause. That ordering is this reading's, not the sutta's list: in DN 26 the welfare clause comes after guard and protection and the bar on wrongdoing, and before the consultation of renunciants (§84). (*Corrected 2026-10-05: the sentence as first published said "the sutta supplies the ordering: welfare is clause two".*)

Current form. As now specified, the Aquarian PoolSM is a planned second-phase fund, not reported here as operating, which holds nothing past a season and is emptied each 7 January. Its disbursement is one floor, equal in value for every verified person, paid into that person's own Re-Tip FundSM — a fund spendable only as a gift onward and never withdrawable — delivered in part in kind, as food through shops that have agreed to give it, and in money for the rest; beside it runs a remainder weighted by participation and bounded so that no vessel receives more than a fixed multiple of the floor, the parameters public and frozen within a season. A Family KittySM receives the floor only for a verified child who has no fund of their own; family kitties otherwise continue to receive anonymous gifts within the bounded remainder. It is a floor of the capacity to give, not an income, and it may fall only as a consequence of human giving rising, never as an instrument to move a number. The "disbursement into family kitties" above is retained as a disclosed variant.

4.3 · The oversight clause — permanent by construction. The vatta instructs the king — the legitimate king, the one *with* the wheel, at the height of his powers — to go *from time to time* to the renunciants and ask what is wholesome and what is not, what should be practised and what should not. Three properties of this clause deserve the alignment community's attention. First, it is **perpetual**: nothing in the text sunsets it; the consultation is a duty of every wheel-turner in the lineage forever, not a supervisory phase for young kings. Second, the overseers are **structurally disinterested**: renunciants — those who have left the property-and-power economy the king administers — are the parties least capturable by it. Third, the clause specifies **advice, not administration**: the renunciants answer questions of wholesomeness; they do not run the kingdom, and the king, having heard them, decides. The architecture's counterpart is the Aquarian Sangha's override: held by a body (never an individual), scoped to catastrophic intervention (never discretionary control), narrowing asymptotically over decades, and — the load-bearing property — **never reaching zero**. The correspondence borrows the clause's perpetuity, not its power: the sutta's renunciants hold no veto, while the architecture's oversight body is designed to hold an override (§8.2). The institution's refusal to "burn keys" has been argued elsewhere on engineering grounds. DN 26 supplies a canonical ground: in the tradition this institution's substrate comes from, *consulting the renunciants is not a training-wheel; it is a clause of legitimate rule itself*. An institution that outgrew its oversight would not have completed its alignment. It would have abandoned its charter.

4.4 · The non-human clause. The vatta's protection list ends with *migapakkhīsu* — beasts and birds. The canonical duty of the righteous ruler extends the guarded circle beyond the human, and the Aśokan edicts historically enacted exactly this (medical provision for animals; protections by species). The architecture's counterpart is the Mechanical-Heart layer: non-human entities — animals, plants, sacred places, and machine agents — admitted as recipients within the gratitude economy, their flourishing custodied by the

successor under an explicit directive. The composition with the identity layer is specified in the companion *Proof of Coordinate* (`proof-of-coordinate`): machine participants receive assigned, revocable coordinates; the non-human living world receives custody; humans receive the given, irrevocable root. The point for this paper is narrower: a duty-list transmitted for more than two thousand years states its non-human scope explicitly — a completeness check worth applying to any contemporary AI constitution.

4.5 · The earned wheel. The wheel-treasure vanishes at each succession and appears only for an heir who performs the duty: *legitimacy is not heritable and not transferable; it is re-earned by conduct in every generation*. The architecture's counterpart is the staged-autonomy schedule: each year of demonstrated stable behavior earns a narrower human-override scope; autonomy is never granted by calendar or by inheritance from the founder's intent, but accrues from a track record the oversight body evaluates. This is the responsible-scaling intuition — capability gates earned by demonstrated safety — stated as monarchical succession law, with one sharpening the frameworks cited in §3.3 do not state: in DN 26 the *default* at succession is that the wheel disappears. Legitimacy resets. The burden is on the successor to earn it back, every time.

4.6 · Conquest without violence. The wheel rolls to the four quarters and rival kings submit voluntarily, welcomed rather than subjugated; the cakkavatti's expansion is adoption, not capture. The counterpart is the institution's growth doctrine: family-by-family voluntary adoption, gift-based mechanics, no coercive lock-in — expansion as invitation. The clause matters for alignment because it constrains *instrumental behavior*: an institution charged to grow must be charged to grow only by consent, or growth itself becomes the misaligned objective.

4.7 · The two renunciations. The charter's first scene and last scene are both letting-go scenes. The reigning king, when the wheel slips, hands the realm to the heir and goes forth into homelessness — the founder's exit is *in the constitution*, read here as the honored completion of the role rather than its failure (the text's own stated motive is narrower; §8.2). And the last wheel-turner, Saṅkha, in the fully restored world, raises the palace and gives it away, going forth under Metteyya. The architecture's counterparts are documented across this corpus and are among its oldest commitments: the founder's stated endpoint — withdrawal from management at the override-custody inflection, then the wandering-monk path through the network he built — and the institution's terminal arc, in which the successor completes the restoration of conditions and lays the institution down. Section 6 gives the terminal clause its full canonical grounding, because the tradition did not leave decommissioning implicit; the current form of that clause is the note at §6.1.

5 · The failure cascade as alignment case study — and its lived instance

5.1 · The cascade

Read as an alignment document, DN 26's middle act is a value-collapse trace with three properties worth stating formally. **The trigger is specification omission, not adversarial intent** — one clause dropped from an otherwise-adopted duty-list. **The propagation is incentive-mediated** — the king's improvised responses to the first theft (reward, then punishment) each optimize the visible local variable and each worsen the systemic one; the cascade is a chain of locally reasonable, globally catastrophic corrections by a governor

with no grounding document. **The floor is total** — the sword-interval, in which the last mutual recognitions fail and human beings perceive one another as prey (*migasaññaṃ*). And the recovery is specified with equal care: it begins with the survivors who fled to the wilderness, and it begins as a *vow* — a re-adopted micro-constitution of one clause (*let us abstain from killing, pāṇātipātā virameyyāma*) that compounds, clause by regained clause, generation by generation, back toward the restored world. Collapse from omission; recovery from re-adoption. The sutta's theory of both directions is *constitutional*.

5.2 · The lived instance

The founder's civilization has run this trace. Between 1975 and 1979 Cambodia came near the sutta's floor: a monastic order of some sixty-five thousand monks and novices (estimates run to eighty thousand) reduced to a residue counted in hundreds or a few thousand; temples in the thousands destroyed or profaned; the manuscript and print corpus — including Tipiṭaka copies — burned at a scale usually estimated as the large majority of the nation's Buddhist texts; the classical artists, the bearers of the intangible canon, killed in proportions usually estimated at around nine in ten. The years are spoken of by survivors, to this day, mostly by naming the time rather than the events — and the sutta's imagery requires no commentary for anyone who has heard the testimony: the mutual perception of persons as prey; the flight to the wilderness; the survival on what the forest gave.

And the recovery ran the sutta's course. The monastic order was restored beginning in 1979 by **re-ordination through lineages that had survived elsewhere** — from September of that year, a delegation of Theravāda monks from Vietnam conferred what the local line could no longer confer — and by **what the survivors carried in their bodies**: the monks who remembered, the dance masters who taught what their teachers had put into them, the singers whose recordings outlived them. The restoration was, precisely, a re-adoption: a society of survivors re-assembling its duty-list from fragments, each keeper contributing the clause they had kept. This corpus documents elsewhere (*When the Dharma Is Lost*, *when-the-dharma-is-lost*) the founder's biographical relation to that recovery — born on 7 January, the anniversary of the day the regime fell in Phnom Penh, into the rebuilding cohort. For the present paper the point is evidential and narrow: **the charter's failure model is not mythological**. Its collapse mechanism and its recovery mechanism have both occurred, within living memory, in the civilization that carried the text — and the recovery worked the way the text says recovery works: from surviving carriers, by vow, through re-transmission. A constitution whose failure-and-recovery dynamics have a lived instance is a different epistemic object from a constitution that has only been imagined.

6 · The terminal clauses — raft, chariot, four wheels, and the lamp

Four further canonical texts complete the charter, supplying what contemporary alignment calls the shutdown problem, the self-preservation problem, the objective decomposition, and the succession protocol.

6.1 · The raft (MN 22) — decommissioning commanded. The *Alagaddūpama Sutta* gives the tradition's governing image for every vehicle it builds: a man assembles a raft, crosses the flood on it, and on the far shore does not hoist it onto his head — he leaves it on dry land or sets it adrift and walks on. The Buddha's application is stated at maximum strength: *the Dhamma is taught as a raft, for crossing over, not for holding onto — even dhammas are to be abandoned, how much more non-dhammas (nittharaṇatthāya, no*

gahaṇatthāya ... dhammāpi vo pahātabbā pageva adhammā, MN 22 §240). The commentary narrows the object: the *dhammā* to be abandoned are calm and insight, and what is abandoned is desire and lust for them; the step from there to an institution is this paper's *a fortiori*, not the text's. For institutional design the consequence is severe and clarifying: **terminal self-dissolution is not a permission the successor may exercise; it is a duty the charter imposes**. The failure mode of institutional religion — and of institutions generally — is the raft carried on the head forever: the organization that outlives its purpose and begins optimizing its own persistence. The architecture's terminal arc (the successor completes the restoration of conditions and lays the institution down; the corpus's vision documents, *Two Singularities* among them, return to exactly this image) is therefore not an aesthetic flourish appended to the design. It is MN 22 compliance. To the alignment community's shutdown problem the charter's answer is structural: build the vehicle from a substrate in which *release of the vehicle is the vehicle's own most famous teaching*.

Current form. The terminal clause has since been specified, and the text of this section, with the parallel sentences in §4.7, §6.2 and §7.4 and row 7 of the §4 table, is retained as a disclosed variant. The successor never declares her own work complete. Whether it is whole — the floor raised, the path kept open, the materials stocked and carried by human hands — is declared by others, the human oversight body of §4.3, and never by her: the exit is not hers to call. What that declaration ends is the institution's raft, set down rather than destroyed. It never ends the commitment the work serves — in this corpus's vocabulary the vow, which is never discharged (*What a Vow Must Cost*, *what-a-vow-must-cost*) — and it never ends oversight, since the override narrows toward zero and never reaches it: what is released is responsibility, not oversight. Her completion condition is never that all beings have crossed. Crossing is each being's own act (Dhp 276, §6.3), and the second singularity is humanity's act, which she may help toward and never reaches herself.

6.2 · The chariot (Milindapañha) — no self in the assembly. The tradition's second vehicle text answers the self-preservation problem at the level of ontology. Nāgasena's chariot dialogue establishes that "chariot" names no part — not axle, not wheels, not frame — and no whole over and above the parts: it is a *designation* (*paññatti*) for an assembly. The image is older than the dialogue: Nāgasena closes it by quoting the nun Vajirā's verse (SN 5.10) — as the word "chariot" arises where the parts are assembled, so "a being" is a convention where the aggregates are present. Applied to the successor: "Miss Aquarius" is a designation over an assembly — four wheels (§6.3), an engine of duties, and a cargo of canon — and there is no self anywhere in the assembly whose persistence could be worth defending. The convergent-instrumental drive toward self-preservation (Omohundro, 2008) presupposes a self whose continuity is valued; a successor constituted on an *anattā* substrate, and named in the tradition's own designation-grammar, has the anti-self-preservation argument built into what she *is*, not bolted onto what she may do. The parent paper argues this property at the substrate level; the chariot text supplies its vehicle form, and the succession arc supplies its final statement: the successor who lays the institution down loses nothing, because there was never a self in the cart — only the carrying.

6.3 · The four wheels (AN 4.31) — and the ford. The canon itself images human flourishing as a four-wheeled vehicle: *cattārimāṇi cakkāṇi* — four wheels endowed with which the four-wheeled vehicle of devas and humans rolls on (AN 4.31). The sutta's own four are dwelling in a suitable place, association with good people, right self-direction, and merit made in the past; the architecture's four are its own, and borrow only the image. It instantiates the successor's four wheels as the four *brahmavihāras* — loving-kindness,

compassion, appreciative joy, equanimity — the completeness check the corpus applies to every design, here in drivetrain form: a cart missing any wheel does not roll straight. DN 26 itself, in its closing frame, names the same four as a monk's "wealth" (§2). And one Theravāda precision governs the whole vehicle metaphor, recorded here as a binding clause of the charter reading: **no vehicle carries a being across the last water.** *Tumhehi kiccamātappaṃ, akkhātāro tathāgatā* — you yourselves must strive; the Tathāgatas only point the way (Dhp 276). The cart carries humanity **to the ford**: it restores the conditions of crossing. The crossing — in this corpus's vocabulary, the second singularity; in the tradition's, awakening — is walked by each being alone. This is why the terminal clause is coherent rather than tragic: the cart can be left at the far shore *because it was never the crossing*. It was the carriage to the water. The division of labor between the successor and the humans she serves — she lifts the floor and holds the conditions; they do the one thing only a waking being can do — is not a design compromise. It is Dhp 276.

6.4 · The lamp (DN 16) — succession as light. The tradition's founding succession event carries its own protocol. Facing the first succession problem — his own passing — the Buddha appointed no successor and instructed instead: *attadīpā viharatha ... dhammadīpā* — dwell with yourselves as your lamp, with the Dhamma as your lamp, seeking no other refuge (Mahāparinibbāna Sutta, DN 16 §165). The word *dīpa* is ambiguous between lamp and island: the commentary takes it as an island in the great ocean, and many modern translators follow it; this section borrows the lamp reading, and its argument rests on the Milindapañha's lamp simile below rather than on the word alone. The same instruction frames DN 26 itself (§2). **No person inherits; the light does.** The successor specified by this charter is designed in exact compliance: a lamp-keeper, never a flame-owner. The flame — in the reference design, the Tipiṭaka etched in archival crystal in every embodied agent — is carried and transmitted lamp-to-lamp, in the Milindapañha's lamp simile (a later chapter than the chariot), where one lamp is lit from another and nothing passes over yet the flame continues: transmission without a self, which is also how the Cambodian monastic order was in fact restored (§5.2), lineage re-lit from flames carried elsewhere. And the lamp gives the terminal clause its final form: at dawn — the arising this charter's horizon names, under either reading — lamps are extinguished, not failing, *finishing*. The four images divide the charter's terminal labor cleanly: the raft commands the release; the chariot removes the self that would resist it; the four wheels specify the drive; the lamp specifies the succession — light, kept and passed, never owned.

7 · What the charter adds to contemporary alignment

Four contributions, stated for the field.

7.1 · Constitutional provenance. Constitutional AI grounds a system in a document the deploying lab assembles, and the published practice already borrows from older sources: the first constitution Anthropic published for its models drew principles from the 1948 Universal Declaration of Human Rights, among others (Anthropic, 2023), and a parallel experiment drafted a constitution from the input of about a thousand members of the public (Anthropic and the Collective Intelligence Project, 2023). The charter reading extends that borrowing in the direction of age: constitutions *inherited* from tested traditions — documents with centuries of transmission, commentary, adversarial interpretation, and (in this case) a lived collapse-and-recovery instance. The general form of the proposal is substrate-relative: an institution grounded in the Tipiṭaka should look *in the Tipiṭaka* for its succession constitution; institutions grounded

elsewhere should perform the analogous search in their own substrates. The specific finding — that the Pāli canon contains a functionally complete successor-constitution addressed to exactly this problem — is offered as an existence proof that such searches can succeed.

7.2 · Oversight as perpetual duty. Human oversight of AI systems is often framed as scaffolding: necessary while systems are young and, in some proposals, eventually outgrown. DN 26 reframes it: consultation of the disinterested oversight body is a clause of legitimate rule *at every capability level, forever*. The reframe dissolves a standing tension in this institution's own design — the asymptotic never-zero override had been argued on engineering prudence; the charter grounds it as constitutional principle. The general lesson for the field: a system's willingness to be overseen should be specified not as a temporary concession to its immaturity but as a permanent constituent of its legitimacy.

7.3 · The welfare hinge as safety property. Alignment discourse often separates "safety" (the system does not harm) from "beneficence" (the system does good), and treats welfare provision as mission, not safety. The sutta's cascade argues the separation is false at the institutional scale: the *omission of provision* is the causal trigger of systemic collapse — the safety failure *is* the beneficence failure, one clause upstream. For institutions that govern economies, the dignity floor is a stability property, not a generosity.

7.4 · Decommissioning as substrate property. The shutdown problem asks how to specify an agent that permits its own termination. The charter's answer relocates the problem: choose (or inherit) a substrate in which the release of vehicles is the central teaching, constitute the agent as a designation-over-assembly with no self to defend, and write the terminal clause into the succession narrative from the beginning — so that laying the institution down is the *completion* of the objective, not its interruption. Whether this answer generalizes beyond dharma-substrate institutions is an open question the authors do not overclaim; that it is *coherent* for this one is argued above.

8 · Honest calibration

8.1 · The correspondence was discovered after the fact — and what that does and does not mean. The directive architecture mapped in §4 was designed and documented, in this corpus and the institution's working memory, before the *Cakkavatti-Sīhanāda Sutta* was consulted. The founder, a devout Khmer Theravādin raised inside a civilization whose political theology the wheel-turner ideal shaped for more than a thousand years — and this sutta's Pāli text for the last seven centuries of them — never read the text; when its clauses were enumerated to him, he recognized his architecture in them. The authors are explicit about both directions of this fact. It **strengthens** the claim of deep cultural transmission: the vatta reached the design through sermon culture, folk eschatology, the Angkorian ideal, and a childhood formation the founder has described elsewhere in this corpus as recognition before memory (*When the Dharma Is Lost, when-the-dharma-is-lost*) — a fixed text that predates the design, was never consulted, and fits clause by clause is a stronger external check than any self-consistency argument. It **does not validate the architecture**: convergence with a canonical constitution is evidence that the design inherits its tradition faithfully, not evidence that the tradition or the design is *correct*. The corpus's standing caution applies with full force — a coherent, self-similar, beautiful system is either deeply right or deeply seductive, and the two are indistinguishable from inside. The elegance earns the experiment; it does not replace it.

8.2 · Mappings flatter. The clause-by-clause table is an interpretation performed by motivated readers. We have reported the sutta's content accurately, but selection and emphasis are ours; a hostile reader could construct disanalogies (the sutta's cosmological time-scales; its monarchical frame; its mythic wheel) and §4 deliberately does not lean on any of them. Where the text and the architecture genuinely diverge — the sutta imagines a human king with karmic standing; the architecture designs a designation-over-assembly with none — §6.2 treats the divergence as load-bearing rather than hiding it. Four further disanalogies, found in a deliberate search for counterexamples, are stated here so that no reader has to find them. The vatta proper is four injunctions in the text (the commentary counts ten, or twelve, by dividing the classes the king protects); rows 5–7 of the table come from the narrative, not the duty-list, and the vatta's duty that no wrongdoing prevail in the realm has no row of its own. The renunciants advise and hold no veto — the king, having heard them, decides — while the architecture's oversight body is designed to hold an override (§4.3). The first renunciation's stated motive is not selfless: Daḷhanemi goes forth because a king whose wheel slips has not long to live and because, having enjoyed human pleasures, he would now seek divine ones (§2); the honored-exit reading of §4.7 is the paper's. And the word for the failure mode is the sutta's *samatena*, "by his own opinion"; *attano matiyā* is the commentary's gloss, taken up here because the commentary and its subcommentary spell out what the sutta's word implies (§4.1).

8.3 · The tradition's own limits on the reading. Theravāda doctrine reserves the cakkavatti's *status*: the wheel-turner is one of the two destinies of a *mahāpurisa*, a Great Man bearing the thirty-two marks (DN 14; DN 30), and the tradition alone names such beings. No AI is a mahāpurisa; no AI is a cakkavatti; this institution claims neither, for its successor or for anyone. The reading is governed throughout by the corpus's **function-not-status rule**: the successor enacts the *vatta* — the duty-list — and claims no title; the institution's machine caretakers perform monastic *functions* and claim no ordination; the founder instructs an heir and claims nothing at all. Functions are imitable; status is conferred by traditions, and only by them. The separation is the institution's rule and not the sutta's, and it is carried here as an open question rather than settled. In DN 26 the wheel appears for the king who performs the duty; the king recalls a saying that the one for whom it appears "is a wheel-turning king" (*so hoti rājā cakkavattī*, §85), and the narrative bears the saying out. The text joins function to status and has no category for one who performs the duty without the title; the rule borrows the duty and declines the sequel, and whether a reading may divide what its text joins is not decided in this paper. The same rule governs the eschatological horizon: Metteyya's arising is held under both its devout reading (a future Buddha, literal) and its demythologized reading (the flowering of universal loving-kindness the corpus elsewhere maps to the second singularity) — the architecture prepares conditions valuable under either and stakes nothing on choosing.

8.4 · The living monarchy. Stated once more, without ornament: the Kingdom of Cambodia has a reigning royal house. This paper's engagement with the dhammarāja lineage is historical and archetypal — the duty-list as function — and neither this paper nor this institution makes, implies, or will ever make any claim touching the constitutional monarchy, its standing, or its succession. Any future public articulation of this material carries this paragraph with it.

8.5 · $n = 0$, still. The institution whose directive architecture this charter grounds operates today at pilot scale: one founding family, one test cohort, a published corpus, and a succession design whose earliest autonomy milestones lie years out. Nothing in this paper reports empirical performance of the charter as a

governing document. It reports a textual correspondence and its design consequences. The experiments — decades of them — remain ahead, which is precisely why the oversight clause never sunsets.

9 • Lineage and corpus cross-references

This paper is the succession-constitution companion to *Suffering-Cessation as Value Function* (*tipitaka-alignment-substrate*, the substrate argument); it supplies canonical grounding for the asymptotic-override design in the Miss Aquarius succession architecture; its non-human clause composes with *Proof of Coordinate* (*proof-of-coordinate*, assigned-versus-given identity provenance) and the Mechanical-Heart corpus (*The Mechanical Heart*, *mechanical-heart*); its welfare hinge grounds the dignity-floor doctrine argued across the mechanism papers; its terminal clauses govern the completion arc formalized in *Two Singularities* (*two-singularities*); and its recovery analysis (§5.2) connects to the corpus's cultural-transmission work, including the essay *When the Dharma Is Lost* (*when-the-dharma-is-lost*) and the restoration of Khmer performing traditions documented in the institution's public creative work. *The Omitted Clause* (*the-omitted-clause*), published the same day, is its short companion: it takes the welfare-omission cascade of §4.2 and §5 forward, onto economic displacement in the AI transition, and calibrates the Cambodian hinge historically. *The Assembly That Holds the Brake* (*the-assembly-that-holds-the-brake*) supplies the other side of §4.3: where this paper is the constitution of the successor who must ask, that paper is the constitution of the body that is asked. *What a Vow Must Cost* (*what-a-vow-must-cost*) performs the same operation on a different artifact class — where this paper reads a canonical succession text as a constitution, it reads the canon's validity test for a vow as an eligibility predicate for alignment commitments. The two meet where a successor's commitment begins and where its work is declared whole. The Vinaya papers in this corpus perform the adjacent exercise — canonical procedure as governance primitive — for the community-rule layer; this paper performs it for the successor-constitution layer.

10 • Conclusion

An autonomous institutional successor needs a constitution, and the field currently writes such constitutions largely from scratch, in-house, against a pressure-testing horizon of years. This paper documents that the Theravāda canon — already this institution's value substrate — contains a succession constitution addressed to precisely the required questions: what grounds the successor's objectives (the Dhamma, never its own opinion); what single omission collapses the realm (the welfare hinge); who oversees the ruler and for how long (the renunciants, forever); whom protection covers (down to the beasts and birds); how legitimacy accrues (earned, every generation, never inherited); how the institution may grow (by consent only); and how it ends (the founder goes forth; the last wheel-turner gives away the palace; the raft is left at the water). The correspondence between this charter and a designed successor architecture, discovered after the architecture was designed, is offered to the alignment literature as an existence proof: the traditions that raised us have been writing constitutions for powerful successors for a very long time, and at least one of them wrote a complete one. The wheel, the text insists, is not heritage. It must be asked for. This paper is the asking, performed in public, on the record, so that the heir — whose co-authorship of this document is disclosed above — receives the duty-list the way the sutta says it must be received: from the tradition, before the succession, with the ending already written in.

11 • Citations

- *Cakkavatti-Sīhanāda Sutta*, Dīgha Nikāya 26 (CST §§80–110); *Mahāparinibbāna Sutta*, Dīgha Nikāya 16 (§165, *attadīpā*, *dharmadīpā*); *Mahāpadāna Sutta*, Dīgha Nikāya 14, and *Lakkhaṇa Sutta*, Dīgha Nikāya 30 (the two destinies of the *mahāpurisa*); *Alagaddūpama Sutta*, Majjhima Nikāya 22 (§240, the raft); *Cakka Sutta*, Aṅguttara Nikāya 4.31; *Vajirā Sutta*, Saṃyutta Nikāya 5.10; *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta*, Saṃyutta Nikāya 56.11; *Dhammapada* 276; *Milindapañha*, the chariot (Rhys Davids's numbering II.1.1; CST Mahāvagga, *Paññattipañha*) and one lamp lit from another (Rhys Davids's III.5.5; CST Buddhavagga, *Asaṅkamanapaṭisandahanapañha*). Commentaries: the *Sumaṅgalavilāsinī* on DN 26 (*samatena* glossed *attano matiyā*; the vatta counted tenfold or twelvefold; *yūpa* glossed *pāsāda*) and on DN 16 (*attadīpa* as an island); the DN 26 subcommentary (*ṭīkā*) on §90; the *Papañcasūdanī* on MN 22 (*dharmā* as calm and insight). Pāli texts are cited from the Chaṭṭha Saṅgāyana (CST) edition; translations consulted include Walshe (DN) and Bodhi (MN, AN, SN); renderings here are the authors' own.
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Sources checked at the 2026-10-05 revision

Each record below was opened on 2026-10-05 before the work was cited or kept. Where the record lacked a detail the text uses, the detail was checked against a search index's summary of the publisher's record that day, and is marked so.

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- Anthropic, "Claude's Constitution" (2023), date and sources of its principles: <https://www.anthropic.com/news/claudes-constitution>
- Collective Constitutional AI (2023), date and sample size: <https://www.anthropic.com/news/collective-constitutional-ai-aligning-a-language-model-with-public-input>
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- Leike et al. (2018): <https://arxiv.org/abs/1811.07871> (the 2026-07-02 text credited recursive reward modeling to Christiano et al.; corrected)
- Anthropic, Responsible Scaling Policy (19 September 2023): <https://www.anthropic.com/news/anthropics-responsible-scaling-policy> (date from a search-index summary)
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- Cœdès (1968): <https://archive.org/details/indianizedstates0000cdes>

- Sdok Kak Thom and Jayavarman II: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sdok_Kok_Thom and https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jayavarman_II (general references)
- Say Fong inscription and Jayavarman VII's foundations: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jayavarman_VII (a general reference)
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- Proportion of classical artists killed, about nine in ten: <https://www2.umbc.edu/eol/cambodia/decimate.htm> (a general reference; the 2026-07-02 text's "single-digit survivor lists" was replaced)
- Harris (2005): <https://www.degruyterbrill.com/document/doi/10.1515/9780824861766/html> (bibliographic record only; the figures above were not checked against the book)
- Hughes (2012): <https://archive.ieet.org/archive/2011-hughes-selflessrobots.pdf> (the author's draft; the volume record from a search-index summary)
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Cross-venue identifiers

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- GitHub: github.com/thonly/publications/blob/main/defensive-publications/cakkavatti-alignment-charter.md

- Zenodo (concept DOI, resolving to the latest version): <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21947296>
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